



Photographs by A PRABHAKAR RAO

LORD'S GIFT: Mass marriage; Governor N.D. Tiwari, Chief Minister Y.S.R. Reddy and B. Karunakara Reddy greet newly-weds (right)

priests of TTD and others hired for the occasion solemnise the weddings. TTD employees arrange for the kalyanamastu in tandem with district officials, public representatives, social activists and volunteers called Srivari Sevaks. To lend a touch of glamour to the occasion, local celebrities are invited to greet the newly-weds. TTD has conducted the kalyanamastu thrice—the latest on March 9—spending more than Rs 12 crore with 19,140 couples having taken their marriage vows so far. The number is bound to grow, judging by the concerted efforts to spread awareness and incentives coming in the way of those entering into wedlock. Local committees are offering clothes and other freebies depending on the generosity of philanthropists in different places. Some donors have come forward to pay for short honeymoon trips for those getting married in Tirupati. The Andhra Pradesh State Road Transport Corporation is planning to offer subsidised tickets for a three-day round

trip to the newly-weds.

Bhumana Karunakara Reddy, TTD chairman, says the primary goal of kalyanamastu is to strengthen the Hindu marriage system and also to support those who are not in a position to get married without taking loans. Legend has it, Lord Venkateswara, the presiding deity at the Tirumala Temple, had to borrow money for his marriage with Goddess Padmavathi. "It is believed He does not want others to suffer the same fate and through kalyanamastu He is performing the marriages with His own money. It is a simple ceremony performed by the priests on behalf of Lord Venkateswara in accordance with the shastras, in which the bridegroom ties the nuptial knot with the bride with the mangalsutra sent from the Tirumala Temple," explains Reddy.

With the involvement of district officials, kalyanamastu has gained an additional dimension. The Krishna district administration plans to allot houses under the Government's

Indiramma programme to the newly weds who opt for these short weddings. This, says Navin Mittal, former district collector, fulfills the old Telugu proverb: "*Pelli chesi choodu...illu katti choodu...*", which implies that the two challenges of life are marriage and building a house.

But the coupling of the wedlock and allotment of houses has sparked criticism that kalyanamastu is being used for political mileage. Refuting the charges Reddy says, "our goal is direct and simple, protection and propagation of Hindu dharma and ancient traditions. If we pay heed to criticism, we can't take up any of the projects to propagate the Hindu dharma and to prevent conversions from Hinduism to other faiths."

The massive exercise is not always without its share of glitches though. In a bizarre incident during the latest kalyanamastu, two persons were electrocuted when they came in contact with high-tension wires while installing a 30-ft high cut-out at Karapa in East Godavari district.

No less sensational was the attempt to drag out a 43-year-old bridegroom moments after his marriage in Khammam by the kin of his first wife, in the same event. As the rituals of the mass wedding ceremony were halfway through, brothers of his first wife stormed into the marriage hall and kicked up a ruckus. He tied the mangal-sutra in a hurry as they vainly tried to drag him out. Embarrassed officials forced him to leave the hall only to take him to the police who grilled him for not informing the hosts that this was his second marriage. He claimed he had gone ahead with the marriage only after consulting his college-going daughters from his first wife and informing the bride, Dhanalakshmi.

Such small misadventures aside, TTD is planning to set up an exclusive kalyanamastu trust as Reddy's plan "is to perpetuate the Hindu marital system which is the most sacred among all institutionalised marriages". He is optimistic that with the flux of time even the well-to-do will opt for these less ostentatious marriages. And it may well lead prospective newly-weds as well as parents of eligible boys and girls to chant louder "in Venkateswara we trust."